prince Akbar upon the battlements. According to the contemporary chronicler Nizamuddin Ahmad, Maham Anaga threw herself upon the child and clutched him to her bosom, placing herself between the guns and the prince. In the end, after months of skirmishing, Kamran was forced to flee and Humayun took back Kabul. Once peace was re-established, however cursory, the rituals of Mughal courtly life continued. One of the most important aspects of the upbringing of a Mughal prince was his education and this was now undertaken in the case of Akbar. But Akbar would prove to be a spectacularly indifferent student, giving rise to all manner of speculations and insinuations for centuries.

♦

The official beginning of a Timurid mirza's education was the second event after his circumcision which marked the end of his infancy. A thorough education allowed a prince to rule wisely and be able to gauge men and help raise them to their full potential. According to the scholar Munis Faruqui, 'a well educated prince combined the best qualities of a man of the pen…and a man of the sword'. Humayun, an extremely literary man himself, and fully conversant with the solemnity of the occasion, chose the propitious hour for beginning this grave task after much consultation with 'acute astrologers and time-knowing astrolabe-conners'. But when that hour came around, viz. 20 November 1547, while the teacher Mullazada Mulla Asamudin Ibrahim was waiting, the 'scholar of God's school had attired himself for sport and had disappeared'. The unfortunate teacher was soon dismissed on the seemingly whimsical charge of being too fond of pigeon-flying, though he seems to have instructed his pupil rather too well in this respect, as kabootar-bazi was a sport that Akbar would enjoy to distraction. The next teacher assigned to the royal pupil was Maulana Bayazid but he fared no better than his predecessor and was similarly discharged. After this, it appears that tutors were not exactly rushing forward to take on the task because Abu'l Fazl admits that Humayun had to draw lots between three men and, finally, Maulana Abdul Qadir was chosen. Akbar, however, was at that time 'continually giving his attention to that wondrous creature the camel…He used to observe and contemplate,' wrote the indulgent Abu'l Fazl, 'the strange make and ways of camels, which were the biggest animals in that region and…made serious reflections on… their endurance and patience'. Patience would have certainly been required of the camels as Akbar led them around by a rope, raced them against horses, and fed them